The zebra mussel

The case of the zebra mussel demonstrates the diverse ways to approach invasive species control, and the challenges that result. Zebra mussels are small, fingernail-sized mollusks with a dark-striped shell. The mussel is native to Eurasia but was discovered in the Great Lakes area of North America in 1988, probably carried there in ballast water discharged from ships traveling from Europe. Since then, zebra mussels have spread throughout the Midwestern United States, and have been found as far west as California.

The zebra mussels attach themselves to clams and other mussels, filtering out algae that the native species need for food to survive. They also clog water intake pipes used for power plants and drinking water supplies. Current control mechanisms include chemicals, hot water, and filtering systems. While each has had some success, none of these solutions has been capable of safely eradicating the mussels. As a result, they continue to spread throughout the waterways of the US.

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